

51 Abimelech

Gideon's son who killed his brothers to become king, and died under a millstone dropped by a woman.

Abimelech was a son of Gideon, the judge who had refused to be king, by a concubine from Shechem. After Gideon died, Abimelech won Shechem's backing, hired reckless men, and killed seventy of his brothers on one stone. Only the youngest, Jotham, escaped. Shechem made Abimelech king for three years. Jotham's fable of the trees and the bramble came true: Abimelech and Shechem turned on each other, and Abimelech died when a woman dropped a millstone on his head. Judges tells it as God repaying evil.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Avimelekh</i> , "my father is king"
Family	Son of Gideon by a concubine in Shechem (Judges 8:31)
When	Soon after Gideon's death; no firm date
Key places	Shechem, Ophrah, Mount Gerizim, Thebez
Key people	Jotham, Gaal son of Ebed, Zebul
Reign	Three years (Judges 9:22)
Not the same as	Abimelech king of Gerar (Genesis 20; 26)
New Testament	Not named

"Thus God rendered the wickedness of Abimelech, which he did unto his father, in slaying his seventy brethren: And all the evil of the men of Shechem did God render upon their heads: and upon them came the curse of Jotham the son of Jerubbaal."

Judges 9:56–57, KJV

The life of Abimelech

Judges gives no calendar dates; on the early date of the Exodus the judges run c. 1375–1050 BC.

In Gideon's lifetime	● Born in Shechem Gideon has seventy sons by many wives. A concubine in Shechem bears him another son, Abimelech. <i>Judges 8:22–23, 30–31</i>
After Gideon's death	● Wins over Shechem Abimelech asks Shechem: seventy rulers, or one who is "your bone and your flesh"? They side with him and give him seventy pieces of silver. <i>Judges 8:33–9:4</i>
At Ophrah	● Kills his brothers With hired men he kills his brothers "upon one stone." Jotham, the youngest, hides and survives. <i>Judges 9:4–5</i>
At Shechem	● Made king Shechem makes Abimelech king. From Mount Gerizim, Jotham tells his fable of the trees and the bramble, then flees. <i>Judges 9:6–21</i>
Three years on	● Shechem turns God sends an evil spirit between Abimelech and Shechem. Gaal son of Ebed boasts against him, and Zebul secretly warns Abimelech. <i>Judges 9:22–33</i>
The next days	● Destroys Shechem Abimelech takes the city and sows it with salt. About a thousand die when he burns the stronghold of the god Berith. <i>Judges 9:34–49</i>
At Thebez	● Dies A woman drops a piece of millstone on his head from a tower. He orders his armor-bearer to kill him, so no one will say a woman slew him. <i>Judges 9:50–55</i>

Key activities

Judges says Abimelech killed "threescore and ten" sons of Gideon, yet Jotham escaped, so many readers take seventy as a round figure. Judges never calls Abimelech a judge; his story works as a warning.

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- 1 Played on family ties.** He asked Shechem's leaders to choose one ruler from their own kin instead of seventy. *Judges 9:1-3*
 - 2 Paid with temple silver.** He hired "vain and light persons" with seventy pieces of silver from the house of Baal-berith. *Judges 9:4*
 - 3 Murdered his brothers.** He killed Gideon's sons on one stone at Ophrah, and only Jotham escaped by hiding. *Judges 9:5*
 - 4 Took the title of king.** Shechem crowned him, and he reigned over Israel three years. *Judges 9:6, 22*
 - 5 Crushed a revolt.** He set ambushes against Gaal's forces and drove them back, then took Shechem the next day. *Judges 9:34-45*
 - 6 Burned the tower of Shechem.** He cut boughs on Mount Zalmon, piled them against the stronghold and set it on fire. *Judges 9:46-49*
 - 7 Died by his own order.** Struck by a millstone at Thebez, he had his young armor-bearer thrust him through. *Judges 9:50-54*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abimelech.

Old Testament

Judges 8:29–9:57	This is the main account.
Judges 10:1	Tola arises "after Abimelech" to defend Israel.
2 Samuel 11:21	Joab expects David to recall how a woman on the wall killed Abimelech at Thebez. There Gideon is called Jerubbesheth.
Echoes	A similar fable of a thistle and a cedar appears in 2 Kings 14:9. "He that rolleth a stone, it will return upon him" (Proverbs 26:27).

New Testament

Echoes	"All they that take the sword shall perish with the sword" (Matthew 26:52). "Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap" (Galatians 6:7). Jesus teaches that the one who would be great must serve (Mark 10:42–45), the opposite of Abimelech's grab for power.
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For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Abimelech give the men of Shechem for choosing him (Judges 9:1–3)?
2. *Understand:* In Jotham's fable the useful trees would not leave their work to rule, but the bramble would. What was he saying about Abimelech?
3. *Apply:* Abimelech used family loyalty to get what he wanted. Where are you tempted to use people to get ahead?
4. *Apply:* Judges says God repaid both Abimelech and Shechem. Is there a wrong you need to leave in God's hands this week instead of paying it back yourself?